ideas that he had tailored for India. After offering a few pleasantries to Jinnah, whom he called a ‘distinguished leader’, Nehru ran through a long laundry list of issues that differentiated his vision of India from Jinnah’s.[2]

Nehru first asserted that he fundamentally disagreed with Jinnah on how to tackle the political problems of the day. According to Nehru, all Indians ‘without any difference of caste, religion or political party’ were faced with the same political situation of living under colonialism.[3] It was a political situation that they shared with many other oppressed peoples around the world. From ‘Palestine, Syria, Egypt, Java, Indo-China and several other countries’, Nehru stressed during a string of speeches he gave in the run-up to his Lucknow encounter with Jinnah, the proper response to that situation could only be ‘to attaining independence’.[4] As India’s struggle was interconnected with a broader global issue around imperialism, local issues could only be solved by approaching them from an international perspective.

In the past, Nehru outlined, Jinnah had often accused him of focusing too much on the international situation and ignoring the immediate issues plaguing Indians. Nehru readily accepted that he was ‘always fighting shy of the immediate problem [with which he is faced], whether they are in the domain of politics […] or in other spheres of national activity’.[5] He disarmingly conceded this was partly ‘due to the fact that I am not competent to deal with the immediate problems’.[6] But more importantly, it had to do with his theory of change through which he saw ‘the whole of the world’ transforming.[7] According to this theory of change, Nehru elaborated at some length, problems of an immediate nature appeared to him as mere placeholders for more significant questions lurking in the background.[8]

In Nehru’s unspooling of history, taking the occasional cue from Marx and Hegel, ‘the forces of progress’ were constantly rubbing against the ‘the forces of reaction’. Yet, for most people, it was difficult ‘to draw a line between the two because there are so many middle forces’.[9] These middle forces or ‘vested interests’ muddled the picture by appealing to earthly ‘emotions and urges’.[10] Speaking directly to Jinnah, Nehru identified the